

including Mr. Davis—were scheduled to speak. He even provided me with a free ticket and a press pass.

The conference was held in late January at a Marriott hotel and marina. This hotel was built on the edge of the intracoastal waterway and was surrounded on two sides by cabin cruisers the size of World War II destroyers. On some of these boats, helicopters were strapped to the decks where the rubber dinghies are usually found. Antique furniture and grand pianos were visible through the cabin windows. Gorgeous women in string bikinis tanned themselves on deck, and you could smell the coconut oil halfway down the pier.

A more stimulating environment for a discussion of investments could hardly be found. I remembered Mr. Del Dotto's message from Leonardo da Vinci, "Consider the ends first," and here several were tied up to the dock. I also thought of an exposé on stockbrokers I'd seen in the library: *Where Are the Customers' Yachts?* The author hadn't found any—which was the point of his argument—but these luxurious vessels I could see with my own eyes. After watching a few of the one-sixteenth-dressed, piña-colada-scented deck hands, I promised myself I'd invest in a boat as soon as I could afford it.

(Later, I was disappointed to learn that the yachts parked outside the Marriott were owned by people who had nothing to do with the conference, some of whom may have enriched themselves in a business I'd rather not mention.)

Inside the hotel, down the corridor just beyond the lobby, were 20 or so booths where you could learn about investment opportunities in jojoba beans, cashews, rare coins, diamonds, German windmills, oil-gas leasing, thoroughbreds, the New York futures exchange, rental movie projectors, and preferred rarities, as well as stocks and bonds, plus "free financial analysis," computer trading systems, and more. In the hallway I overheard one exhibitor enlisting recruits for an investor's tour of South Africa, where you'd meet some contented gold miners and see the positive side of apartheid ignored by the media. Another exhibitor was explaining how to depreciate stallions over five years. Another was touting cancer-cure stocks and precious-metal stocks in alternate breaths. "Have you ever tried pistachios—not as a snack, but as the chance of a lifetime?" asked the nut-farm syndicator.